

UNIFORMS AND EQUIPMENT

Until the latter years of the 19th century, a soldier went into battle wearing the same colourful outfit he wore on the parade ground, but this changed with the advent of revised infantry tactics. The need for concealment led to the adoption of khaki, field-grey, and similar neutral tones. Protective body armour, which was abandoned when plate and mail proved vulnerable to bullets, was not to return until the development of flak jackets in World War II.



Water bottle in holder

Axe in frog

Stirnpanzer

Nickel/silicon steel

► BRITISH UNIFORM

Date 1902

Origin UK

Material Wool

British troops in India took up khaki uniforms as early as the 1850s. They were formally adopted in 1897, and the darker shade shown here came into use in 1902. Also shown is the belt of the 1908-pattern webbing system, with ammunition pouches and a bayonet “frog” – a strap for suspending an item from the belt.



Service dress tunic

◄ STORM TROOPER EQUIPMENT

Date 1916

Origin Germany

Material Leather, cotton, brass

German storm troopers were issued with a belt kit that included bags for grenades to supplement ammunition pouches, frogs to hold an axe and the favoured short bayonet-cum-trench knife, and a water bottle.

► GERMAN STORM TROOPER UNIFORM

Date 1916

Origin Germany

Material Wool, leather

When the first “Stormtroop” (*Sturmabteilung*) detachments went into action in 1916, they adopted a combat dress with leather reinforcing patches on the elbows and knees, along with lighter boots. Based on the medieval sallet, the original *Stahlhelm* helmet had ventilators above each temple, from which a much heavier brow plate could be hung. This plate, the *Stirnpanzer*, weighed 4kg (8¾lb) and was worn only when absolutely necessary.



Reinforcing leather patch

Distinctive reinforcing band



▲ ITALIAN UNIFORM

Date 1915

Origin Italy

Material Wool, steel

Italy switched to a grey-green uniform, similar to the German *feldgrau*, in 1915. The army also adopted a steel helmet similar to the French “Adrian”, with its reinforcing band running back across the crown.